joining and seeing the conditions, voluntarily withdrew. Thus, there were still slots open at the NDA main campus, which had to be filled up. Since sending fresh call letters, waiting for the new aspirants to join, etc., would have taken time—time lost for training—it was decided to shift some ten or twelve of us from the OTS to the main NDA. So, after just about three weeks at Madras, I was once again on a train, but this time bound for Pune. All these developments were, of course, unknown to my parents, or even to us for that matter, till we were peremptorily told to pack up and be ready to move the next morning. As a result, I remember little of my stay at the OTS, except that I did report sick once for a sprained ankle. It was just a sprain, a common occurrence among most fresh cadets on account of the sudden unaccustomed-to exercise. A crepe bandage and a couple of painkillers and it was back to training. There was no sympathy or mollycoddling.

We arrived at Pune in the early hours of the morning. The transport from NDA was to come only in the evening as per a laid-down schedule, so were told to stay put near the office of the Movement Control Officer (MCO). I don't remember whether I took anyone's permission or not, but since there was enough time to spare, I caught a bus and went home. My mother opened the door and saw one scarecrow in NDA mufti[2] standing at the doorstep. It took her an instant to recognize me before she burst into tears. She was certain that I had run away from the Academy, so gaunt had I become. I gorged on a good home-made meal (this time I didn't puke), which lifted both our spirits, me with a belly-full of food and my mother content to see her laadka. When I explained that I had been transferred to the campus at Khadakwasla, she was both relieved and happy. Much too soon it was time to head back and rejoin my coursemates (CM) at the station, lest I be declared AWL (Absent Without Leave).

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